

MESA AI-Native Track · Founder's Office · Cohort C4

Case 1 Seed Data - published/

Meera Pillai / Skinstinct - 15 pieces (4 LinkedIn posts + 11 email newsletters)

LINKEDIN POSTS (4)

— linkedin_post_001 —

Category: Ingredient Deep-Dive

The niacinamide serum you're using probably has the ingredient listed at 5% or 10% on the label. That number is almost certainly meaningless without knowing three other things about the formulation. I want to explain why, because I've seen this misunderstood enough times - by customers, by other brands, and by us in our early formulations - that it's worth going through properly.

Niacinamide is water-soluble and relatively stable, which is why formulators like it. It doesn't oxidise the way Vitamin C does, it doesn't degrade under light exposure the way retinol does. But it has one significant formulation sensitivity that almost nobody talks about on product labels: it converts to niacin at low pH. Niacin is not inert. It causes vasodilation. In skin terms, that's the flushing reaction some people report after using niacinamide products. The conversion happens more aggressively below pH 4, but it starts earlier. If a niacinamide serum is formulated at pH 3.5 to maximise AHA or BHA activity in the same product, you're not getting the niacinamide benefits you paid for. You're getting a diluted version at best, and a flushing risk at worst.

Most serums don't list their pH on the label. This is legal. It is also not helpful.

The second thing the percentage doesn't tell you is the delivery context. Niacinamide at 5% in a water-heavy base with no penetration support behaves differently from 5% in a formulation designed for skin retention. I'm not talking about anything exotic - base ingredient selection, how the formula is structured, the order in which ingredients are combined during manufacture - these all affect how much of the listed concentration is actually available at the skin barrier. We spent several months adjusting the base of our serum before the CoA results matched what we were seeing in application consistency tests. The label percentage stayed the same the entire time.

The third thing is batch consistency. A small number of formulations in a batch manufactured at lower temperatures will have different ingredient dispersion than those processed at the optimal

temperature. If the supplier's batch testing protocol is sampling at the start and end of a run rather than at multiple points through it, variance exists that the label never captures.

I am not making a case that niacinamide doesn't work. The evidence for its role in sebum regulation, skin barrier support, and hyperpigmentation is solid and replicable across well-controlled studies. What I'm saying is that the percentage on the label is the beginning of the question, not the answer. The pH of the formula, the delivery base, and the batch manufacturing process together determine whether you're actually using what the label claims.

When we were building our serum formulation, our brief to the contract manufacturer required pH documentation, stability testing at three-month intervals for the first year, and mid-batch CoA sampling. These are not unusual requirements. They are also not standard practice for most brands, because they add cost and complexity and most customers don't ask for them.

You should ask for them. Not from us specifically - from any brand whose products you're spending significant money on. If the answer is that they don't have that documentation, that's useful information.

— linkedin_post_002 —

Category: Founder Story

In 2021 I was sitting in a stability review meeting at the pharma company I worked for. We were reviewing a skincare formulation - not a drug, but a cosmeceutical that was going through our standard documentation process before market release. The active ingredient was listed at 8% concentration with a 24-month stability claim on the product file.

I asked about the pH of the finished formula. The answer was 3.2.

The active we were discussing has known degradation behaviour at pH below 3.8. At pH 3.2, you would expect significant concentration loss within the first 8 to 10 months under standard storage conditions. The 24-month stability claim was based on accelerated testing that did not account for this specific interaction - the testing protocol had been inherited from a previous product with a different base.

Nobody else in the room asked about it. The formulation passed review. I left the company 7 months later.

I want to be precise about what I'm not saying here. I'm not saying the people in that room were incompetent or malicious. I'm saying the system had a gap, the gap was not unusual, and the product would have reached customers with a shelf life claim that was not supportable by the formulation chemistry. This happens across the industry at various scales. Some of it is carelessness. Some of it is commercial pressure. Most of it is that the gap between formulation

science and marketing communication is wide enough that claims get made without ever being checked against the data behind them.

Skinstinct came out of the specific discomfort of sitting in that room and understanding exactly what was in front of me. I am not trying to build a brand story around a single meeting. I'm saying that moment was the first time I thought: what would it look like to do this with the documentation actually in order from the beginning?

Three years later I can say it looks like more CoA requests than our contract manufacturer initially expected, more questions about pH testing intervals than most clients ask, and a stability testing protocol that adds to our timelines and costs more than the industry standard approach. It also looks like being able to answer when a customer asks what the pH of our serum is, because we have the data and we're not embarrassed by it.

That is the entirety of the founding rationale. It is not a particularly inspiring story. It is a documentation gap and a decision to do something about it.

— linkedin_post_003 —

Category: India-Specific Context

In the 12 months to June 2025, 23% of our product returns came from customers who mentioned the texture or feel of the product as the reason. When I mapped those returns against the customer's location, the pattern was immediate: 71% were from customers in cities with average annual humidity above 70%. Mumbai, Chennai, Kochi, Kolkata.

We were using a formulation originally developed for a climate it was not designed for.

Most skincare formulations in the Indian market are either imported directly or developed using ingredient systems and efficacy benchmarks from European and Korean markets. This is not inherently a problem - the actives science translates. But the vehicle, the base that carries the actives, is calibrated for a different climate. A moisturiser formulated for Oslo in February has different occlusive requirements than one for Chennai in August. The emollient-to-humectant ratio, the occlusive percentage, the overall texture that comes out of the formulation - these are downstream of climate assumptions that were made by the formulator for their market, not ours.

The specific issue in our case was that our first serum base was too film-forming for high-humidity skin conditions. In a dry climate, that film helps retain moisture. In Mumbai in July, the same film traps sweat under the product, changes the skin feel within 20 minutes of application, and produces exactly the greasy, heavy sensation our customers were describing. The actives were intact. The formulation was working as designed. It was designed for the wrong context.

We reformulated using a lighter base system with adjusted humectant-to-occlusive balance. Returns from humid cities dropped to 8% in the following quarter. The active ingredient concentrations stayed identical.

I bring this up not because our reformulation is a selling point - it should have been right the first time. I bring it up because the climate assumption problem is almost never discussed openly in Indian skincare. Brands import formulations or use contract manufacturers running formulations designed elsewhere, and the adaptation step gets skipped because it's expensive and because customers often can't articulate what's wrong beyond "it doesn't feel right." The texture data usually exists somewhere - in returns, in reviews, in customer service logs. The connection to climate and base formulation chemistry is rarely made.

Our customer return data is not proprietary. We track it because it's useful, and the pattern it revealed was one we should have anticipated from the start. If you're building a skincare brand for the Indian market, the first question to ask your contract manufacturer is what climate the base formulation was validated for. If the answer is anything other than "we'll run stability testing under Indian temperature and humidity conditions," that's worth investigating further.

— linkedin_post_004 —

Category: Industry Transparency

Last September I was at a trade fair in Mumbai. One of the booths had a banner that said: CLINICALLY TESTED. DERMATOLOGIST APPROVED. The product was a moisturiser.

I asked the brand representative what the clinical testing involved. She said she'd find out and get back to me. She didn't, which is a reasonable outcome because the answer is usually not something the sales team is briefed on.

"Clinically tested" is not a regulated claim in India under current cosmetic labelling guidelines. It means whatever the brand chooses it to mean. In practice, I've seen it applied to: a 4-week consumer perception study (participants rating their own skin feel), an in-vitro ingredient efficacy test run by the ingredient supplier rather than the brand, a safety patch test conducted on 25 people to confirm no irritation response, and one case where I could not find any documentation at all for what the testing referred to.

None of these are clinical trials in any meaningful sense of the term. None of them would pass review in a pharmaceutical efficacy claim context. All of them are technically defensible under current cosmetic regulations because the regulations don't require the claim to be substantiated in any specific way.

I want to be careful here because I'm not saying all efficacy claims in the skincare industry are fabricated. Some brands do robust independent testing. Some ingredient suppliers publish

genuinely useful data. The problem is that "clinically tested" as a label claim tells the customer nothing about which category they're looking at. The words are the same whether the testing was a 500-person double-blind study or 12 people rating how their skin felt after two weeks. There is no way to know from the label.

What you can do is ask. Not at a trade fair booth, but in writing, to the brand's customer service. Ask what the clinical testing referred to on the label involved: how many participants, what the study design was, who conducted it, and whether the results are available. If the brand has real data, they will usually share it without much resistance, because real data is a commercial asset and brands are proud of it. If the answer is vague or doesn't arrive, that is also useful information.

We list exactly what our product testing covers on our website. Sample size, study type, who ran it. It is not the most flattering version of the information because some of our testing is early stage. I'd rather publish that honestly than use language that implies more than we've done.

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EMAIL NEWSLETTERS (11)

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— newsletter_001 —

Category: Brand Philosophy

Subject: What you're actually signed up for

Hi,

I want to start with something direct: this list is not going to be a place where I sell you things.

I will email you when we launch a new product, and I'll explain exactly what's in it and why we formulated it the way we did. But that's not what most of these emails will be. Most of them will be about formulation science - the gap between what skincare labels say and what the chemistry behind them means. That gap is real, it's wide, and I find it genuinely interesting to write about.

Some background on me, briefly. I spent two years working in pharmaceutical formulation before starting Skinstinct. I'm not a dermatologist. I don't have a medical degree. What I have is working knowledge of how ingredient systems behave under different conditions, how stability documentation works, and enough familiarity with formulation chemistry to read a CoA and understand what it's telling me. That background informs everything we make. It also informs what I write about.

I started Skinstinct because I couldn't find skincare brands that were honest about the gap between ingredient claims and formulation reality. Most labels list what's in the product. Very few explain whether those ingredients are in the product at concentrations that do anything, in a base that allows them to do anything, with stability documentation to support the shelf life claim on the packaging. These are not obscure questions. They are the basic questions, and the answers are usually not published anywhere.

What you'll get from this list: honest explanations of skincare science, written plainly. When I don't know something, I'll say so. When the research is inconclusive, I'll say that too. When I think something in the industry is being misrepresented, I'll say that directly and explain what the actual evidence shows.

If you bought a Skinstinct product and that's why you're here, thank you. If you signed up because someone sent you this link, thank you too. Either way, I'll try to make the emails worth the time they take to read.

Meera

— newsletter_002 —

Category: Formulation Science

Subject: What an "active" actually does (and why most explanations stop too early)

Hi,

I want to talk about how actives work, because I think most explainer content on this topic stops exactly one step before the part that matters.

The standard version goes like this: "Niacinamide regulates sebum production and reduces hyperpigmentation." This is true. It is also almost entirely useless information for evaluating whether a specific product does anything.

An active ingredient does something when it reaches the site where it needs to do it, in a concentration sufficient to trigger the relevant biological response, in a form that is still intact and bioavailable at the point of contact. All three of those conditions have to be met. The INCI listing on a label confirms that the ingredient was present during manufacturing. It says nothing about whether those three conditions are met in the finished product.

Take penetration. Niacinamide is small and water-soluble, so it penetrates the epidermis without much assistance. Vitamin C is more complicated - ascorbic acid needs to be at a low pH to penetrate effectively, and that creates formulation conflicts with other actives that are pH-sensitive in the opposite direction. Retinol needs to reach the dermis to do its primary work,

which means the vehicle matters enormously. An oil-in-water emulsion behaves differently from an oil-based serum. The base isn't decoration around the active. It determines whether the active arrives.

Then there's concentration. Every active has a minimum effective concentration below which it's doing nothing measurable. For niacinamide, the research supporting sebum regulation starts at around 2% and gets more pronounced at 4-5%. Some studies show benefits at 10%. But below 2%, you're in the range of cosmetic preservative function rather than therapeutic effect. Many products list niacinamide without specifying concentration, because there's no requirement to do so. A product could contain 0.1% niacinamide and list it in the INCI without misrepresentation.

Finally, stability. Vitamin C in its ascorbic acid form is notoriously unstable. It oxidises on contact with air and light. A product that is correctly formulated, correctly packaged, correctly stored, and used within a tight window can deliver effective Vitamin C. The same product left open near a window in a Mumbai summer is delivering progressively less with each use. The concentration on the label reflects the start of the product's life, not the end of it.

I'm not trying to make you distrust every product on your shelf. I'm trying to explain what questions to ask, because the marketing layer has trained most people to evaluate skincare at the ingredient level when the formulation level is where the actual decisions are. "Contains niacinamide" tells you almost nothing. "Contains niacinamide at 4%, pH 5.5-6.0, in a water-based base with documented six-month stability" tells you something.

We publish that information for our products because it exists and because I think you should have it.

More on specific actives in the next few emails.

Meera

— newsletter_003 —

Category: Formulation Science

Subject: pH - the question nobody puts on the label

Hi,

A customer wrote to me last month asking whether she could use our serum with a Vitamin C product she'd been using for years. Her question was specific and good: "Are they compatible?"

The honest answer is: it depends on the pH of both products, and I can tell you ours but I can't tell you the other brand's because they don't publish it.

This is the pH problem in skincare, and it's a frustrating one because it's entirely solvable and mostly unaddressed.

Here's why it matters. Most actives have a pH range within which they function correctly. Vitamin C as ascorbic acid is effective at pH 2.5-3.5. Below that it's irritating. Above that it degrades rapidly. Niacinamide is stable across a wider range but starts converting to niacin at pH below about 4. AHAs like glycolic and lactic acid work as exfoliants at pH 3-4 and become basically inert at pH above 4.5. Retinol is more pH-tolerant but still performs best within a relatively narrow range.

When you layer products, you're mixing pH environments on the skin. If you apply a product at pH 3 and follow it immediately with something at pH 7, what happens in the mixing zone affects how both actives behave. This isn't a hypothetical - it's observable, and it's one reason the same active can produce very different results across different product combinations.

The standard advice to "leave a few minutes between products" is not wrong but it's incomplete. The reason to wait isn't arbitrary. It's to allow the first product to form a partial film and buffer before the second product changes the skin surface pH. Even then, mixing effects happen. The degree to which they matter depends on what the actives are, what concentrations they're at, and the specific pH values involved.

Here's what I want you to take from this. If a product contains an active where pH is critical to function, the brand should either publish the pH or be able to answer it directly when asked. For our serum, the pH is 5.5-5.8 and we document it on every batch. If you're using it with a Vitamin C product, you'd want the Vitamin C product's pH to be significantly lower - ideally below 3.5 - and you'd want to apply the Vitamin C first and give it five to ten minutes before the serum.

If you email any skincare brand asking for the pH of their active product and they can't answer, that tells you something useful about how closely the formulation chemistry is being managed.

Meera

— newsletter_004 —

Category: Ingredient Deep-Dive

Subject: The Vitamin C email (I've been putting this off)

Hi,

I've been avoiding writing this one because Vitamin C in skincare is genuinely complicated and most explanations either oversimplify it to the point of uselessness or go so deep into the chemistry that the practical information gets lost. I'll try to do neither.

Start here: Vitamin C is not a single ingredient. L-ascorbic acid is the form that has the most robust research behind it. It's also the most unstable and the hardest to formulate with. When a product says "Vitamin C" without specifying which derivative, you don't know which of the following you're getting: ascorbic acid, sodium ascorbyl phosphate, magnesium ascorbyl phosphate, ascorbyl glucoside, ethyl ascorbic acid, or several others. These derivatives have different stability profiles, different skin penetration characteristics, and different bodies of evidence behind them.

L-ascorbic acid has the most evidence for collagen synthesis support and antioxidant function at the skin layer. But it oxidises readily - air, light, and heat all accelerate the process. Oxidised ascorbic acid turns orange-yellow. If your serum has changed colour from clear or pale yellow to a deeper orange, you're looking at a product where significant degradation has occurred. The product isn't dangerous, but it's delivering less than it was when you opened it. How much less depends on how it was stored, how often it was opened, and how long ago you bought it.

In our own formulation testing, we found that L-ascorbic acid at the concentrations worth using - above 10% - required airless pump packaging, a pH below 3.5, and a specific antioxidant support system to maintain stability across a 12-month period under standard storage conditions. Without all three of those things in place simultaneously, the concentration dropped measurably within 4-6 months. That's a meaningful finding, because most products sit in a bathroom exposed to steam and light and temperature variation for longer than that.

The alternatives - especially ethyl ascorbic acid and sodium ascorbyl phosphate - are more stable and easier to formulate at higher pH, which makes combining them with other actives more straightforward. The trade-off is that the direct efficacy research is thinner. Sodium ascorbyl phosphate converts to ascorbic acid on the skin, but the conversion rate varies and the evidence for comparable efficacy at the same concentrations isn't as strong. That doesn't mean it doesn't work. It means the evidence base is different, and some products use the more stable derivative while marketing it against the efficacy data for the less stable one.

I want to be honest about something: we don't currently sell a Vitamin C product. I have been trying to formulate one that I'm actually satisfied with for about 14 months. The stability requirements for L-ascorbic acid at an effective concentration, in packaging that isn't prohibitively expensive for a product in our price range, in a base that works in humid climates, have been harder to solve than I expected. That's not a story about our inadequacy - it's a story about why this particular ingredient is genuinely difficult to do properly, and why a lot of products in this category are either using it at ineffective concentrations or using more stable derivatives while implying the research for ascorbic acid.

When we get it right, I'll tell you exactly what we did and why.

Meera

— newsletter_005 —

Category: Brand Philosophy

Subject: Why there's no fragrance in anything we make

Hi,

The shortest version of this email: fragrance is the ingredient category with the highest rate of contact sensitisation in cosmetics, the regulatory framework around it allows almost everything to be hidden under a single label term, and I decided the case for including it wasn't strong enough to justify either of those things.

The longer version.

When a cosmetic product lists "fragrance" or "parfum" on the INCI, that term can legally cover a mixture of anywhere from a handful to several hundred individual chemical compounds. Most of them are undisclosed. Some fraction of those compounds are known allergens - the EU currently requires disclosure of 26 specific fragrance allergens above certain concentrations, and that list has been expanded several times as more sensitising compounds have been identified. The 26 compounds on the list are not the only problematic ones. They're the ones where the evidence was strong enough to mandate disclosure.

Contact sensitisation to fragrance compounds is not the same as an immediate allergic reaction. Sensitisation develops over repeated exposure. The first ten times you use a fragranced product, you might notice nothing. At some point, the immune system has seen the compound enough times to mount a response, and subsequent exposures trigger a reaction. The timing is unpredictable, the reaction can be severe, and once sensitised, you often react to multiple products because fragrance compounds appear across many categories - skincare, haircare, cleaning products, air fresheners. The sensitisation is permanent.

I'm not saying fragranced products will sensitise everyone who uses them. The rate across the general population is estimated at somewhere between 1-3% for significant sensitisation, with higher rates reported in people with existing skin conditions. That's not a majority. But it's also not trivial, and the cost of sensitisation to the individual who develops it is high.

The case for fragrance in skincare is essentially aesthetic and commercial. Products that smell pleasant sell better. Some customers make purchase decisions based on scent experience. These are real and legitimate commercial considerations. I made a different choice because I don't think the aesthetic value justifies the sensitisation risk, and because I don't need the disclosure gap to sell products. If something we make is worth using, I'd rather that be because of what the formulation does, not what it smells like.

Everything we make is fragrance-free. That includes the preservative system, the emollients,

and any carrier ingredients where scented variants are commonly used. If you're managing sensitive skin or have had reactions to fragranced products in the past, that's the relevant commitment on our end.

Meera

— newsletter_006 —

Category: Consumer Education

Subject: The one thing I want you to stop doing with SPF

Hi,

Reapplying sunscreen is not optional. I know this isn't new information. I'm going to explain why the specific way most people apply SPF means they're not getting the protection the label claims, because I think understanding the mechanism changes the behaviour more than repeating the instruction does.

SPF ratings are tested under standardised conditions: 2mg of product per square centimetre of skin. That's the application amount the rating is based on. A 2022 study from the University of Liverpool measuring real-world SPF application found that most people apply between 0.5-1mg per square centimetre - roughly a quarter to half of the tested amount. At half the tested amount, an SPF 30 product delivers protection closer to SPF 5-6. This is not a rounding issue. This is the difference between meaningful protection and almost none.

The second issue is the SPF in moisturiser problem. I get questions about this regularly, and my position is simple: SPF in a moisturiser cannot replace a standalone sunscreen as your primary UV protection. The reason is the application amount issue I just described, compounded. People apply significantly less moisturiser than sunscreen. The SPF in a moisturiser is rated assuming the same 2mg/cm² that no one achieves even with a dedicated sunscreen product. In practice, SPF 15 in a moisturiser, applied the way most people apply moisturiser, is delivering almost no meaningful UV protection.

There's also a formulation consideration. Sunscreen filters need to be evenly distributed across the skin surface to provide the protection the rating claims. A thick, even, deliberate sunscreen application achieves this. A quickly applied moisturiser blended into the skin as part of a morning routine does not. The filter distribution matters as much as the concentration.

What this means practically: if sun protection matters to you - and for long-term skin health in India, at our UV index levels, it should - you need a dedicated sunscreen product applied generously, applied last in your routine before sun exposure, and reapplied every two hours of continuous outdoor exposure. The moisturiser with SPF is fine as an additional layer. It is not a substitute.

I'm not selling a sunscreen. I want to be clear about that. This is not a setup for a product launch. I just find the gap between how SPF products are marketed and what the application science actually shows to be significant enough that I want to explain it plainly.

Meera

— newsletter_007 —

Category: Formulation Science

Subject: Ceramides and the barrier - let me explain what we're actually talking about

Hi,

"Barrier repair" has become one of the most used phrases in skincare over the last few years, to the point where I think most people have a vague sense that it means something good for their skin without a clear picture of what the barrier is or what repairing it involves. I want to fix that.

The skin barrier - technically the stratum corneum - is the outermost layer of the epidermis. It's not really a wall. It's more accurately described as a matrix of dead skin cells surrounded by a lipid mixture. That lipid mixture is approximately 50% ceramides, 25% cholesterol, and 15% free fatty acids, with the remainder being other lipid types. The ratio matters. The lipids don't function as a simple seal - they create a layered structure through which water can be retained and controlled and through which external irritants can be resisted.

When people talk about a compromised barrier, they're usually describing a state where that lipid matrix is depleted or structurally disrupted. Depletion happens through over-cleansing with harsh surfactants, through over-exfoliation, through environmental exposure, through certain skin conditions. When the lipid structure is disrupted, transepidermal water loss increases - water evaporates from the skin faster than it should - and the skin becomes more permeable to things that should stay out: irritants, allergens, microorganisms.

Ceramide-containing products can support barrier function by replenishing the ceramide component of the lipid matrix. The key word is "can." The ceramides in a topical product need to be the right type (there are several ceramide subtypes, and their functions differ), in a base that allows integration with the existing lipid matrix, and at a concentration that's meaningful. A ceramide listed late in the INCI - after the preservatives - is present at trace amounts that are unlikely to contribute meaningfully to anything.

For our formulation approach, we focus on ceramide NP and AP as the primary ceramide types, because these have the most consistent research behind topical application. We pair them with cholesterol and fatty acids to approximate the physiological ratio rather than delivering ceramides in isolation, because the evidence suggests the matrix effect matters more than high

ceramide concentration alone. We don't currently market any of our products primarily on barrier repair claims. When we have the formulation data to support that claim specifically, we will.

The practical implication: if your skin feels reactive, tight, or easily irritated, and you're using a heavy exfoliation routine or a harsh cleanser, the barrier disruption explanation is plausible and worth addressing before adding more actives. Strip back the routine before building it up.

Meera

— newsletter_008 —

Category: Industry Transparency

Subject: "Natural" in a formulation lab means something very specific. It's not what the label implies.

Hi,

There's a sourcing conversation I've had with our contract manufacturer probably fifteen times over the last two years. It usually starts with me asking about the origin and processing method of a specific ingredient, and it usually reveals a gap between the way that ingredient is described on a product label and what I'd call an accurate description of how it was produced.

The word "natural" in skincare has no regulatory definition in India. It has no standardised meaning in any major skincare market. A brand can call a product natural if it contains some proportion of plant-derived ingredients, if it avoids certain synthetic compounds on an internally defined list, or by no specific criteria at all. The label claim "natural" is not regulated as a material claim and is not subject to verification requirements. This is not a loophole - it's the current state of the regulatory framework.

In a formulation lab, the question of whether an ingredient is "natural" is more complicated than the label implies. Most ingredients that start as plant-derived go through significant processing before they appear in a cosmetic. Cold-pressed oils are pressed at low temperatures to preserve fatty acid profiles - this matters and the claim is meaningful when it's accurate. But I've encountered contract manufacturers who received materials labelled "cold-pressed" on the shipping documentation that arrived with temperature logs showing processing well above what cold-pressing requires. Whether that was a supplier labelling error or something else, the documentation didn't match the claim.

"Plant-derived" is another term that sounds straightforward and isn't. Squalane, for instance, is available in olive-derived and sugarcane-derived forms. Both are plant-derived. Both have very different sustainability profiles and sometimes different purity levels. "Centella asiatica" appears in products as the whole plant extract, as standardised extracts with specific asiaticosides percentages, and as synthetic madecassoside - a compound from centella - all under ingredient

names that a consumer would be unlikely to distinguish.

I'm not saying natural ingredients are better or worse than synthetic ones. That binary is one of the most unproductive framings in skincare. Some synthetics are safer, more stable, and better studied than their natural equivalents. Some natural ingredients are poorly characterised, inconsistently sourced, and more likely to cause sensitisation than the preservatives people avoid because they sound chemical.

What I'm saying is that "natural" as a label claim tells you something about the marketing positioning and nothing reliable about the formulation. If the origin and processing of the ingredients in your skincare matter to you - and they're legitimate things to care about - ask for sourcing documentation. Not every brand will have it or share it. The ones who do, and who can speak to it specifically, have been asking their suppliers the right questions.

Meera

— newsletter_009 —

Category: Industry Transparency

Subject: Clean beauty gets some things right. The rest is making things harder.

Hi,

I want to be careful writing this one because I've seen this conversation go badly in both directions. There's a version that dismisses clean beauty entirely as marketing nonsense, and a version that treats "clean" certification as sufficient reason to trust a product's safety and efficacy. I think both are wrong, and the truth is more specific.

What clean beauty gets right: it pushed a meaningful number of brands to examine their ingredient lists and remove things that were either unnecessary or had reasonable evidence of harm at cosmetic exposure levels. The pressure to justify every ingredient - rather than defaulting to whatever was standard in a previous formulation - has been genuinely useful for the industry. Some of the widely avoided ingredients under clean beauty frameworks have real toxicological reasons to avoid them. Some of the manufacturing transparency requirements that have emerged alongside the movement are good.

Where it gets complicated is in the categorisation logic. Many clean beauty standards operate on ingredient blacklists that mix compounds with strong evidence of harm with compounds that have almost no evidence of harm at the concentrations used in cosmetics, and treat both as equivalent. Parabens are the obvious example. The paraben concern originated from studies showing oestrogenic activity at high concentrations - concentrations many orders of magnitude above what's present in a cosmetic product. The evidence that paraben concentrations in cosmetics cause harm in humans is essentially absent. The substitute preservative systems that

replaced them in many formulations are, in several cases, less thoroughly studied and causing more sensitisation reactions than the parabens they replaced.

I don't use parabens in our formulations, for reasons that are partly pragmatic and partly about customer trust. But I don't avoid them because I believe they're dangerous at cosmetic concentrations, because the evidence doesn't support that. I want to be honest about that distinction.

The claim I find genuinely problematic in clean beauty is the implicit one - that "clean" means safer, better studied, or more efficacious. It doesn't mean any of those things. It means the formulation was reviewed against a particular ingredient list by a particular standard. Those standards differ significantly across certification bodies. A product certified as clean by one organisation can contain ingredients that would fail certification by another.

I'm not telling you to abandon clean beauty standards if they matter to you. I'm saying that "clean" is a marketing category, not a scientific one, and evaluating what's behind any specific certification is worth doing before treating it as a quality indicator.

Meera

— newsletter_010 —

Category: Ingredient Deep-Dive

Subject: Peptides: what the research actually says

Hi,

Peptide serums are one of the categories I get asked about most frequently, and my honest position is more qualified than most of the content on this topic, so I want to explain it properly.

Peptides are short chains of amino acids. Proteins - including collagen and elastin, which give skin its structural properties - are long chains of amino acids. The premise behind peptide skincare is that applying short amino acid chains topically can signal the skin to produce more collagen or perform other structural repair functions. This is called cell signalling, and the mechanism is real. Specific peptides do trigger specific cellular responses.

The research gap is in the translation from mechanism to commercial product efficacy. The peptides with the strongest research behind their cell signalling functions - palmitoyl pentapeptide-4 (Matrixyl), acetyl hexapeptide-3 (Argireline), and a handful of others - show genuine efficacy in in-vitro studies and in some controlled clinical trials. The in-vitro results are consistent. The clinical results are more variable, with effect sizes that range from modest to meaningful depending on the study design, the application frequency, and the concentration used.

Here is the concentration problem, and it's the same problem as almost every other active category. Peptides at effective concentrations in a serum are expensive ingredients. They also need a delivery system that allows them to penetrate the stratum corneum - peptides are generally too large for passive penetration without some assistance, and the vehicle matters significantly. A peptide serum that lists palmitoyl pentapeptide-4 in the INCI but contains it at 0.01% in a water-heavy base is unlikely to deliver clinical effects. The ingredient is present. The formulation conditions for efficacy are not.

I've seen products marketed with language like "contains 7 peptides" or "multi-peptide complex" that, when I've looked at the INCI position of those ingredients, appear to contain each of them at concentrations below where the research shows any meaningful effect. Seven peptides at sub-therapeutic concentrations is not better than two peptides at effective concentrations. It's a label that sounds comprehensive and delivers less than the framing implies.

We don't currently sell a peptide product. I'm telling you this because I want the assessment to be straightforward - I don't have a commercial stake in how you read it. When the research is this concentrated in the delivery and concentration questions, I think the honest thing is to say that the category works, the products vary enormously in whether they're formulated to work, and the label doesn't tell you which category a specific product falls into.

What to look for, if you want to use peptides: concentration information if the brand publishes it, packaging that limits air and light exposure, and independent clinical evidence rather than in-vitro claims alone.

Meera

— newsletter_011 —

Category: Founder Story

Subject: 18 months of Skinstinct. Some data, some honesty.

Hi,

I almost didn't write this email, because most founder retrospective posts I've read are structured as celebration and I wasn't sure I had a celebration version of this year to give you. What I have instead is a more accurate one.

The number I'm most proud of: our repeat purchase rate at 12 months is 67%. In a market where most DTC skincare brands report repeat rates between 20-40%, this suggests that the products are doing what we say they do for a meaningful proportion of the people who try them. I don't know how to separate "the formulation works" from "the communication builds trust" in that number, and probably both are contributing. But I'll take it.

The thing we got wrong that I've been sitting with: our original serum formulation was not designed for Indian climate conditions. I wrote about this in more detail a few months ago, but the short version is that our return rate in high-humidity cities was almost three times what it was elsewhere, and it took us embarrassingly long to make the connection. We reformulated. The numbers improved. The lesson is that having a pharmaceutical background doesn't make you immune to skipping the validation step for the specific market you're actually serving.

The thing I didn't expect: how much of the work of running a skincare brand is communication rather than formulation. I was prepared for the technical problems. I was less prepared for how much time I would spend explaining why something that looks less appealing on a label - no fragrance, no "skin-loving" ingredients, a shorter INCI than most competitors - is actually a considered decision and not a gap in the product. Most customers who ask about fragrance think we left it out by accident. The explanation that we left it out on purpose because of sensitisation data is one I've had a few hundred times now. I don't mind having it. I just didn't anticipate it would be such a significant part of what we do.

What's coming: we have two products in formulation that I'm not ready to talk about in detail. One has been in development for over a year, which is longer than I planned and shorter than it apparently needed. The other is newer and might be simpler, but I've learned not to assume.

I started this email by saying I wasn't sure I had a celebration version. Reading it back, I think what I have is better than a celebration - I have a year that produced specific, useful information about what we're doing right and what needed to change. That's what I set out to build the company around, so it seems appropriate that the first year looks like that too.

Thank you for reading these emails. I mean that specifically, not as a sign-off.

Meera

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